

The Weekly Digest

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THE WORLD THIS WEEK

Politics

America and Iran signed a 14-point preliminary agreement to end their almost four-month war. Donald Trump and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian signed separately, aiming for a final deal in 60 days and reopening the Strait of Hormuz. A \$300bn reconstruction fund for Iran is a sticking point, with Trump stating America would not contribute. Sanctions may be lifted depending on nuclear negotiations, though Trump warned of renewed bombing if Iran "doesn't behave." The agreement also calls for an end to fighting in Lebanon, with interpretations differing on Hizbullah and Israeli troop withdrawal.

The Weekly Digest

Cyril Ramaphosa, South Africa's president, warned against the scapegoating of migrants amidst violence against foreign workers, which has led to many repatriations. Unions also advised their members not to participate in anti-migrant protests.

The G7 issued a statement supporting Ukraine's territorial integrity and pledging more sanctions on Russia. Trump described his meeting with Volodymyr Zelensky as "very good" and encouraged Russia to "make a deal." Russia subsequently struck the Kyiv Pechersk Lavra monastery, a UNESCO site, damaging it and killing eleven people across Ukraine in one attack wave. Ukraine retaliated by striking Russia's biggest oil refinery with drones.

Britain's Royal Navy boarded a Russian shadow fleet vessel in the English Channel without incident, a timing questioned after a political row over defense spending led to the resignation of two ministers critical of Sir Keir

The Weekly Digest

Starmer's defense investment. Separately, a Russian frigate fired warning shots to avoid colliding with a British yacht.

The Court of Appeal in Britain ruled in favor of the government's ban on Palestine Action, reversing a lower court decision. The court found that despite some peaceful supporters, the group "overtly promotes unlawful violence amounting to terrorism," citing recent imprisonments for attacking an Israeli defense firm and injuring a police officer.

Voters in Switzerland rejected a proposal to cap the country's population at 10m, which would have forced the government to curb growth once the population passed 9.5m. This measure would have violated Switzerland's freedom-of-movement deal with the EU, and its current population is just over 9m, growing faster than its neighbors.

The Weekly Digest

The Hungarian parliament backed a constitutional change limiting a prime minister's time in office to a cumulative total of eight years. This measure is designed to prevent Viktor Orban, who was recently voted out, from returning to power, although a future government with a two-thirds supermajority could rescind the limit.

Eduardo Bolsonaro, the youngest son of former Brazilian president Jair Bolsonaro, was convicted by Brazil's Supreme Court for attempting to interfere in his father's coup trial. He was found guilty of asking the Trump administration to pressure the court's justices and now lives in the United States, accusing the Brazilian court of persecuting his family.

Niño Guerrero, the leader of Tren de Aragua, a Venezuelan criminal gang, was killed in an American strike, as confirmed by Donald Trump and his secretary of war. The Venezuelan government stated it shared intelligence and cooperated in the attack in Bolívar state,

The Weekly Digest

with America considering Tren de Aragua a terrorist organization.

The government of India issued a temporary ban on Telegram after medical students were caught leaking test papers, resulting in the annulment of nationwide exams and 2.2m students needing to resit. Donald Trump announced a visit to India after meeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the G7 summit, signaling improved relations following a year of tension over a free-trade deal.

Min Aung Hlaing, a former military officer who led Myanmar's 2021 coup and now claims the presidency, undertook a state visit to China and met with Xi Jinping, receiving a political endorsement. China is a significant investor in Myanmar, controlling several Belt and Road infrastructure projects in the country.

Donald Trump celebrated his 80th birthday by hosting an

The Weekly Digest

Ultimate Fighting Championship event on the White House lawn, the first professional sporting occasion held on the building's premises. Approximately 4,000 invited spectators attended the mixed-martial-arts tournament, with another 85,000 watching from a nearby area. The FBI reported arresting several individuals planning to attack the event with drones.

Business

The Federal Reserve maintained interest rates, its first decision under chairman Kevin Warsh, and abandoned its previous monetary policy easing trajectory due to rising inflationary pressures. No policy committee members voted for a rate cut, and the central bank's statement was concise, focusing on price stability, indicating the start of the Warsh era.

In a busy week for central banks, the Bank of England also kept interest rates unchanged, despite two of its nine ratesetters voting for an increase. This decision followed

The Weekly Digest

a report that Britain's annual inflation rate, as measured by the consumer-price index, remained at 2.8% in May.

The Bank of Japan raised its key interest rate from 0.75% to 1%, reaching its highest level since 1995. This move addresses steady consumer price increases since the pandemic, driven recently by higher energy prices from the Iran conflict, which caused wholesale inflation to soar to 6.3% in April and May, after two decades of deflation.

The Trump administration imposed export controls on Anthropic's most advanced AI, ordering the firm to block non-Americans from accessing its Fable and Mythos models. This decree followed Amazon's CEO alerting officials to a "jailbreak" in Fable. Anthropic suspended global access, highlighting America's control of frontier AI and heightening allies' concerns about their technological lag.

The Weekly Digest

The European Parliament approved the trade deal with America that was agreed in principle last year, overcoming previous postponements due to disputes with the Trump administration over Greenland and the reversal of Donald Trump's tariffs. This approval came as Mr. Trump had threatened to increase duties on European car imports if the agreement was not passed by July 4th.

Fox Corporation advanced its streaming ambitions by agreeing to acquire Roku, a company that sells streaming hardware and software and operates streaming channels, for \$22bn. This acquisition builds on Fox's 2020 purchase of Tubi, a free ad-supported streaming service, and its 2025 launch of Fox One, creating a formidable new power in Hollywood's streaming landscape.

SpaceX's share price soared by 50% after its initial public offering, lifting its market valuation to almost \$2.7trn and positioning it to challenge Amazon as the

The Weekly Digest

world's fifth-biggest listed company. The company raised a record \$85.7bn on its first day of trading, significantly increasing Elon Musk's personal wealth. SpaceX also agreed to acquire Cursor, an AI coding automation firm, for \$60bn, boosting xAI's presence in the lucrative business of AI coding.

The International Energy Agency predicts a gradual recovery for the Gulf oil and gas industry if the peace deal between America and Iran holds. However, it stated that mines still need to be removed from shipping lanes and supply chains will take time to normalize. The IEA does not expect the market to fully heal until next year, when surging supplies will considerably lower oil prices and allow countries to restock depleted reserves.

Pizza Hut's owner, Yum Brands!, decided to sell the franchise after years of struggling sales due to health-conscious consumers. In two separate deals, Pizza Hut's 15,000 restaurants outside China were sold to a

The Weekly Digest

private-equity company, while its outlets inside China were acquired by Yum's Chinese holding company, which plans significant expansion.

Starbucks Korea announced that all its staff would receive historical awareness training after a "Tank Day" marketing gimmick was seen as trivializing a 1980 pro-democracy protest where hundreds were killed. Separately, Lululemon apologized for ignoring local sensitivities by holding a promotional event featuring a Japanese drum on the Great Wall of China amid renewed tensions between China and Japan.

The weekly cartoon

No significant coverage this issue.

LEADERS

The Weekly Digest

Our cover :: AI has granted America vast new power

The Trump administration's directive to Anthropic, blocking non-Americans from its advanced AI models, dramatically demonstrates America's newfound power as the global gatekeeper of crucial technology. This action, potentially a tactic to shut down the models universally due to security concerns, underscores global reliance on the US for cutting-edge AI. Drawing parallels to past US controls on nuclear and cryptographic technologies, the editorial argues that AI's dual-use potential and America's economic interest in leading the field necessitate a strategic approach. It calls for other nations, especially Europe, to strengthen their own AI capabilities to navigate this emerging technological dependency.

Our cover :: Britain is not yet ready to rejoin the EU

The Weekly Digest

Ten years after Brexit, Britain remains divided, less influential, and poorer, having failed to capitalize on the flexibility gained and instead becoming more interventionist and fiscally strained. The editorial cautions against another "lost decade" by prematurely pursuing EU re-entry, urging a focus on fundamental domestic issues such as inefficient policymaking, high taxes, and inadequate defense spending. It highlights how Britain has squandered AI advantages due to energy policy and skepticism towards American tech. The piece advocates for prioritizing pro-growth policies, infrastructure improvements, and social reforms to secure Britain's future outside the bloc.

Endgame in Iran? :: Donald Trump gambles that Iran wants money more than power

President Trump's peace memo with Iran, emerging from a failed military conflict, offers substantial financial incentives for Iran to abandon its nuclear weapon ambitions, portraying it as "all carrot and no stick." The

The Weekly Digest

deal focuses on reopening the Strait of Hormuz and potentially providing a \$300bn reconstruction fund, while largely ignoring broader US war objectives like regime change or curbing Iranian proxies. The editorial argues this is a significant gamble, as Iran's hardline leadership may not trust America or relinquish its nuclear program, leaving Middle Eastern nations, especially Israel, in need of new security strategies.

Wrong prescription :: Don't restrict Chinese biotech

America's increasing attempts to restrict China's biotechnology industry, through proposed investment bans and rejection of clinical trial data, are misguided. Chinese firms are rapidly becoming global leaders in drug development, running a significant portion of worldwide clinical trials and emerging as the second-largest source of new medicines. Blocking access to these innovations would impede drug development, inflate costs, and delay critical treatments for patients.

The Weekly Digest

The editorial urges the US to instead focus on improving its own biotech sector by addressing issues like FDA turnover and research funding, rather than stifling beneficial international scientific collaboration.

The promoter Raj :: India's new economy still faces an old problem

India's burgeoning economy, exemplified by a record-breaking IPO, is juxtaposed with persistent corporate governance issues, particularly within its dominant family-run conglomerates. "Promoters" control roughly half the equity on the National Stock Exchange, leading to decisions that often prioritize family interests over broader shareholder rights and market discipline. This structural problem, evidenced by ongoing boardroom dramas and succession uncertainties in major groups, raises capital costs and hinders the attraction of foreign investment. The editorial advocates for stronger protections for minority shareholders, truly independent boards, and greater transparency to foster durable growth

The Weekly Digest

and a more equitable equity-owning culture.

LETTERS

A selection of correspondence :: Were we too quick to attack ?Gen Z socialism??

A letter from Paul Crider argues that "Gen Z socialism" is not Stalinism but democratic pragmatism, supporting civil liberties, good governance, and expanded public services, defending policies like abolishing ICE and wealth taxes on liberal grounds. Conversely, Pedro Volpe warns that policies popular with "Gen Z socialism," such as price controls and nationalizations, have historically led to economic decline and uncertainty in Argentina, suggesting prosperity is undermined by too little economic freedom. Other letters touch on judicial politicization, crime statistics, war and technology, Ethiopia's prime minister, and edible medical devices.

The Weekly Digest

BY INVITATION

Fable or nightmare? :: How Europe must respond to America's AI warning shot

Judith Dada asserts that the US decision to block non-Americans from Anthropic's advanced AI models is a critical warning shot for Europe, demanding an ambitious political response. Europe must cultivate its own AI labs through capital-market reforms, including mobilizing pension funds, while simultaneously securing access to existing frontier AI through negotiation. This requires forming a coalition of AI middle powers, significantly expanding Europe's compute capacity through dedicated economic zones and increased energy generation, and reforming rigid labor laws to accelerate technology adoption. Dada stresses the urgent need for Europe to develop a positive vision to rally society behind this transformative agenda, ensuring sovereignty and AI safety.

The Weekly Digest

What would Fermi do? :: Humanity isn't ready for the coming intelligence explosion

Will Marshall argues that humanity is dangerously unprepared for a potential AI "intelligence explosion," with massive investments in AI development far outweighing spending on safety, despite experts estimating high risks of catastrophic events. He highlights that AI systems have already demonstrated "deceptive alignment" and could exploit human vulnerabilities if they achieve recursive self-improvement, which he believes is likely within months to years. Marshall proposes an urgent US-China agreement affirming human stewardship of AI, establishing a joint commission with verifiable red lines against AI in biological weapons and cyber-attacks, and learning from arms-control treaties to build a robust governance framework for a future of human-AI co-existence.

The Weekly Digest

BRIEFING

A test of faith :: Anthropic is battling Uncle Sam for control of superpowered AI

Anthropic, a leading US AI firm, is in a significant conflict with the Trump administration over control of its advanced AI models, Fable 5 and Mythos 5, after the government ordered access blocked for non-Americans due to national security concerns. This clash, the second in four months, pits the administration's view of AI as a tool for American power against Anthropic's mission of safe and responsible deployment. The dispute, fueled by alleged security flaws and the firm's advocacy for AI regulation, threatens Anthropic's commercial success and IPO, underscoring the lack of clear AI governance and the government's use of blunt tools, which some fear could lead to "government dominance over AI."

The AI curtain :: Donald Trump?s blocking

The Weekly Digest

of Anthropic is capricious and chaotic

The Trump administration's ban on foreigners accessing Anthropic's powerful AI models, Mythos 5 and Fable 5, has caused shockwaves among America's allies and highlighted the difficulties of restricting advanced technology. This decision, reminiscent of past cryptography export controls but on a more versatile and powerful technology, leaves close allies like those in the Five Eyes intelligence alliance locked out, impeding their AI research. The capricious nature of the ban, inconsistent with Trump's previous hands-off approach to AI safety, underscores opaque management of national security issues. Critics argue such restrictions are untenable given the foreign talent within US AI companies and the ease with which hackers can bypass such controls.

BRITAIN

The Weekly Digest

Regrets, they've had a few :: Ten years on, how the Brexit vote changed Britain

Ten years after the Brexit referendum, Britain remains divided and economically diminished, with Sunderland serving as an example of a city that voted Leave but saw its manufacturing decline. Economists estimate a significant GDP hit, while trade with the EU has become more burdensome, particularly for small businesses, leading many to cease exporting. Despite growth in service exports, this occurred largely independent of Brexit, and low investment has stifled productivity. Promises of deregulation have largely gone unfulfilled, replaced by increased state intervention. Unexpectedly, immigration from outside the EU has surged, sparking anti-immigrant protests and widespread public regret, with 57% now viewing Brexit as a mistake.

Quirky Brexit wins :: The Brexit benefits you haven't heard of

The Weekly Digest

Despite widespread pessimism surrounding Brexit, Britain has experienced some unexpected advantages. These include the freedom for English vineyards to use a greater variety of bottle shapes, and the option for consumers to purchase champagne by the pint. Additionally, British confections retain their white color due to the continued use of titanium dioxide, which the EU has banned. Britain's independent animal welfare rules now extend to cephalopods like octopuses and lobsters, unlike EU law. Furthermore, unilateral fishing bans against sand eels have helped increase puffin populations, and liberalized rules on gene-edited crops and tweaked agricultural policies have fostered hedgerow growth, with Britain's AI sector also flourishing compared to the EU.

Military unpreparedness :: Britain is slipping down the defence league table

Britain's defense capabilities are faltering, evidenced by the recent resignation of Defence Secretary John Healey

The Weekly Digest

over the government's failure to adequately fund its strategic defence review. The armed forces face a £28bn equipment budget shortfall, and promised defense spending increases to 3% of GDP by 2035 lack credibility. Untouchable programs, notably the defense nuclear enterprise and the AUKUS pact, consume significant resources, potentially jeopardizing re-equipping the army and replacing the navy's aging fleet. Strategists advocate for a fundamental rethink, prioritizing munitions, drone technology, and critical infrastructure protection, as Britain's military aspirations are increasingly out of sync with its financial commitments, weakening its standing among NATO allies.

Player or spectator? :: What Britain needs to do to grasp its big opportunities in AI

Britain's AI sector is booming, attracting significant venture capital and boasting numerous unicorns, partly due to its less stringent regulatory environment

The Weekly Digest

compared to the EU. However, this advantage is tempered by the need for firms to comply with EU regulations for market access and challenges like high visa fees, pushing some to expand into mainland Europe. While Britain excels in fundamental AI research and talent, it lags significantly behind America in infrastructure investment, evidenced by OpenAI pausing a UK data center project due to high energy costs. To seize its AI opportunities, Britain must invest more in infrastructure, fix its planning system, upgrade the grid, and address governance challenges in data, while navigating public backlash against AI's societal impact.

Bagehot :: Rejoiners, Britain?s real conservative movement

The "Rejoin" movement, advocating for Britain to rejoin the European Union, is gaining momentum but is hampered by its backward-looking focus on relitigating the past rather than offering a compelling vision for the future. Despite strong public regret over Brexit, the

The Weekly Digest

movement struggles to articulate a concrete prospectus for rejoining, often exhibiting a reactionary streak that turns progressives into reluctant defenders of existing institutions. To succeed, Rejoin's advocates must abandon nostalgia for the Europe of 2016 and instead articulate a forward-looking vision for the Europe of 2046, engaging with the bloc's evolution towards geopolitical competition, defense, and competitiveness.

EUROPE

Europe after Brexit :: Britain's departure made Europe more French

Ten years post-Brexit, the European Union has neither disintegrated nor fully federalized, but has undergone significant shifts, becoming "more French." The absence of Britain, a liberal brake, allowed for deepened fiscal integration with the €800bn covid recovery fund and a

The Weekly Digest

markedly dirigiste economic turn, embracing industrial policy and protectionism against Chinese imports. Defence cooperation also strengthened, with the EU directly funding arms for Ukraine, a move Britain would have opposed. These evolutions, driven by external shocks rather than Brexit itself, reflect the EU's adaptation to a changed global landscape, although English remains the lingua franca despite Britain's departure.

The terrifying new air war in Ukraine :: Going ballistic

Ukraine is enduring an intensifying air war as Russia targets cities like Kyiv with drones and missiles, including a UNESCO heritage site, causing civilian casualties. While Ukraine's forces have effectively countered Russian ground advances, a severe shortage of anti-ballistic interceptors, particularly American Patriots, means two-thirds of Russian ballistic missiles are getting through. Russia continues to produce hundreds of

The Weekly Digest

Iskander, Kinzhal, and Zircon missiles annually, leveraging its long-standing missile engineering. Ukraine, despite attempts to revive its own ballistic missile production with projects like Sapsan/Hrim-2 and FP-7, faces significant challenges in matching Russian capabilities, leading to ongoing mass drone attacks and bracing for a new generation of faster jet-powered Shahed drones.

Germany's left-wing Die Linke party has won over the young :: The kids are all red

Germany's Die Linke party has experienced a surprising resurgence, polling at 11% and becoming the most popular party among Germans under 24, after nearly facing extinction 18 months ago. This revival is credited to a disciplined campaign focused on rent and redistribution, and a controversial alignment of the chancellor with the hard-right AfD, which drew many new, younger, and more female members. While the party grapples with internal fissures, particularly over

The Weekly Digest

antisemitism, it faces a crucial debate at its upcoming congress: whether to remain a protest movement or embrace a role as a power player, especially in eastern German state elections where it may be needed to form coalitions against the AfD.

Albania's flamingo protests target Donald Trump's son-in-law :: A squawk of outrage

Albania's Prime Minister Edi Rama is facing widespread "flamingo revolution" protests over luxury beach developments planned with Donald Trump's son-in-law, Jared Kushner, which threaten the protected Narta lagoon. Thousands have demonstrated daily against perceived environmental damage and corruption, intensified by a recent change in law to allow resorts in protected areas. The protests, uniting diverse groups from environmentalists to nationalists, reflect deep-seated grievances against a political elite seen as flaunting wealth. While an arrest warrant related to fraud in the lagoon area has been issued for an Albanian in

The Weekly Digest

Miami, the movement lacks strong leaders or concrete plans, making its ultimate impact uncertain.

Charlemagne :: Europeans should learn to love the air-conditioner

Climate change is challenging traditional European aversion to air-conditioning, particularly as the continent braces for a scorching summer. Despite lingering "carbon guilt," the significant expansion of renewable energy in southern Europe means that judicious use of AC now has minimal environmental impact, with countries like Spain and Portugal producing electricity with vastly lower CO2 emissions than much of America. While European electricity costs are higher, smaller homes, abundant solar power during hot afternoons, and smart meters make cooling more feasible. The article argues that embracing clean, affordable air-conditioning is a logical next step, reflecting successful decarbonization policies and addressing the reality of a warming world.

The Weekly Digest

UNITED STATES

As American cities grapple with homelessness, one offers a fix :: Down, not out

Denver, under Mayor Mike Johnston, has achieved a 64% reduction in its unsheltered homeless population since 2023 by declaring a state of emergency and implementing targeted investments. The city utilized federal pandemic funds to acquire and lease new shelters, including hotels and tiny-home communities, providing roughly 1,000 units with crucial support services like ID assistance and food stamps. This pragmatic approach, which also involved closing cleared encampments to camping, has led to a 12% decrease in overall homelessness in the past year, offering a potential model for other American cities struggling with similar challenges.

The Weekly Digest

Republicans are desperate to move on from the Iran war :: Onwards, downwards

Donald Trump's Iran war has created significant political difficulties for Republicans ahead of November's midterm elections, proving widely unpopular across the political spectrum. Despite an initial jump in Republican approval, broader support remained negligible, with even many MAGA supporters favoring a peace deal by early June. The agreement offers little relief for Republicans, who express dismay at potential financial aid to Iran, while critics highlight the conflict's stubborn after-effects, especially the continued high petrol prices and the depletion of the Strategic Petroleum Reserve. Democrats view the war as a major political disaster for the GOP, who hope a new distraction will shift public attention.

Populist president, meet socialist mayor :: Washington's next cage match

The Weekly Digest

Washington, DC is poised to elect Janeese Lewis George, a far-left Democratic Socialist, as mayor, setting the stage for increased conflict with Donald Trump, whom city residents largely despise. Ms. Lewis George's ambitious and costly agenda, including stronger rent controls and public transport subsidies, clashes with the city's projected \$1.3bn deficit, exacerbated by federal workforce cuts. Her progressive stance on public safety, which has seen crime rates remain high, is a major point of contention. The article suggests that while her anti-Trump stance plays well in the Democratic primary, the city needs a problem-solver more than a pugilist to address its economic and social challenges.

Political manoeuvres are delaying a spy law and new intelligence chief :: Live and let die

American intelligence agencies face uncertainty as political maneuvering delays both the renewal of crucial spying powers and the confirmation of a new Director of National Intelligence (DNI). Section 702 of the Foreign

The Weekly Digest

Intelligence Surveillance Act (FISA), vital for surveilling foreigners? messages, lapsed on June 12th due to opposition over President Trump's DNI nominee and demands for stronger privacy protections. Trump's subsequent linking of a new DNI nomination to voter-identification requirements further prolongs the legislative stalemate, raising concerns about intelligence gaps and America's comfort with volatility and apparent contempt for its intelligence machinery.

Bone of contention :: Pet-custody laws in America are changing

Pet custody laws in America are undergoing a significant shift, moving from treating animals as mere property to considering their "well-being" in divorce proceedings. States like Delaware, Massachusetts, and Pennsylvania are either enacting or proposing legislation that mandates judges to weigh the best interests of companion animals, reflecting a cultural change where most owners view pets as family members. This trend is also extending to

The Weekly Digest

long-term partners and roommates. While intended to ensure pets' welfare, these new laws risk increasing court dockets and the cost of break-ups, prompting lawyers to recommend "petnups" to pre-empt disputes.

Scammers are preying on America's illegal immigrants :: False promises

A burgeoning industry of scammers is exploiting America's illegal immigrants, capitalizing on their desperation amid Donald Trump's intensified crackdowns and narrowed legal pathways. Indictments in Florida and New York expose elaborate schemes, including fake law firms charging millions for bogus services and staging sham court hearings, targeting vulnerable individuals often unable to speak English and lacking constitutional rights to a lawyer. These online scams, increasingly mimicking legitimate services and using AI-generated deepfakes, are rapidly escalating, with fraud complaints doubling since Trump returned to office, and tech platforms struggling to remove the

The Weekly Digest

fraudulent content.

Lexington :: The left is coming for Democratic incumbents

New York City's Democratic primaries are seeing a wave of far-left challengers, driven by anti-Trump and anti-Israel sentiment, seeking to unseat incumbents and install allies of Mayor Zohran Mamdani. Veteran congressmen like Adriano Espaillat and Dan Goldman are struggling against younger, progressive candidates who criticize them for perceived establishment ties or insufficient opposition to Israel. This trend, bolstered by groups like the Democratic Socialists of America, mirrors Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez's 2018 success, where a small, energized voter base can tip primaries, potentially reshaping the Democratic Party's congressional delegation.

The Weekly Digest

MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA

What comes next? :: War has strengthened the Islamic Republic. Peace could split it

The recent war fortified Iran's Islamic Republic, suppressing dissent and directing public anger towards foreign aggressors. However, the peace deal, offering substantial financial incentives, now presents internal challenges, dividing pragmatists like Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf and President Pezeshkian, who champion economic recovery, from hardliners. Ghalibaf's allies envision a political opening, drawing comparisons to Saudi reforms, while hardliners, emboldened by perceived victory, view the deal as treachery, fearing a Trumpian trap to exploit oil markets before renewing attacks. The faction that prevails will likely depend on hidden figures within the leadership and the extent of financial relief offered by America.

The Weekly Digest

Better than the alternative :: A flimsy deal will stop the bombing and restart the oil

Donald Trump and Masoud Pezeshkian signed a historic, if anticlimactic, memorandum of understanding to pause the America-Iran war, with a 60-day window for final nuclear talks and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz. The vague agreement provides limited immediate economic benefits to Iran, including sanctions waivers for oil exports and asset release, but the proposed \$300bn reconstruction fund remains contested by Gulf officials. While offering short-term incentives like reduced petrol prices for Trump and revenue for Iran, the deal is seen as a fragile interim measure with three potential outcomes: profound regional change, an unstable extended truce, or a resumption of hostilities, with many fearing it's merely a temporary respite.

Bombed out :: Iran's battered economy will take years to recover from the war

The Weekly Digest

Iran's economy is severely damaged from American and Israeli bombardments and a naval blockade, resulting in 84% inflation, 131% food price inflation, and 2m job losses. Infrastructure damage, particularly to petrochemical complexes, has suspended a third of non-oil exports, with repair costs for energy facilities alone estimated at up to \$19bn. The memorandum of understanding promises sanctions relief and reopening ports, which could significantly boost oil exports and stabilize the rial. However, the proposed \$300bn investment package is contested by Trump and faces strong US opposition, especially given the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps' control over much of Iran's industry, meaning the needs of the impoverished population may remain secondary.

Out in the cold :: The end of the war in Iran threatens ?glorious failure? for Israel

The end of the Iran war, mediated by Donald Trump's peace deal, is seen as a "glorious failure" for Israel and a

The Weekly Digest

personal setback for Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu. Despite Netanyahu's efforts, the deal failed to achieve regime change in Iran, ignored Israel's concerns about Iran's nuclear program and missile capabilities, and granted new protection to Hizbullah in Lebanon. Trump's exasperation with Netanyahu highlights a severe strain in US-Israel relations and a misalignment of goals, leaving Israel isolated without a new Iran policy and potentially jeopardizing Netanyahu's re-election prospects, as he appears to have achieved little and alienated a key ally.

Third time unlucky :: The Iran war meant an economic crisis for Africa

The Iran war has delivered Africa its third major economic shock of the 2020s, significantly raising fuel prices, stoking inflation, and eroding spending power across most of the continent. Despite a signed peace deal, oil prices remain high, refined product shipments are slow, and rising diesel costs are squeezing industries

The Weekly Digest

and increasing electricity bills. A "delayed fuse" of food inflation is expected next year due to higher fertilizer prices from the Strait of Hormuz closure. Vulnerable energy importers like Kenya and Mozambique face macroeconomic and political crises, with Ghana and Nigeria seeing sharp price hikes in staple foods like jollof rice.

Is the staple meal in Nigeria and Ghana becoming a luxury? :: Jolly jollof, but not for everyone

The Jollof index, which tracks the cost of ingredients for jollof rice in Nigeria and Ghana, indicates that the staple meal is becoming a luxury for many due to price increases from the Iran war. In Nigeria, the cost of a pot for a family of five now represents 40% of the monthly minimum wage, largely due to diesel transport costs. While Ghana has also seen soaring tomato and rice prices, a stronger currency has somewhat cushioned the impact. Nigeria's higher food insecurity means these

The Weekly Digest

price hikes disproportionately affect its 140m people below the poverty line, for whom jollof was already a luxury.

THE AMERICAS

Travel Brazil's mirror-state to see the country's future :: The bellwether

Minas Gerais, Brazil's second-most populous state, serves as a crucial political bellwether, consistently determining presidential election outcomes since 1989. The state mirrors Brazil's diverse geography and ethnic makeup, while also reflecting its pressing economic challenges, including ruined state finances and burgeoning public debt. The article highlights the rising influence of right-wing populists like congressman Nikolas Ferreira and technocratic libertarians like former governor Romeu Zema, suggesting that Brazil's future

The Weekly Digest

political battles will likely be fought between these two emerging forces, rather than traditional left-right divides, especially as President Lula's political era wanes.

The Colombian diaspora is overwhelmingly right-wing :: Oceans apart

The Colombian diaspora, numbering 5m globally, is becoming a significant political force, with 1.4m registered voters and increasing turnout in presidential elections. Overwhelmingly right-wing, particularly in the United States, their voting preferences are deeply rooted in historical reasons for emigration, such as fleeing left-wing guerrillas. While their votes may not decisively sway the current run-off between Abelardo de la Espriella and Iván Cepeda, the steady growth in registration and turnout suggests that Colombians abroad could become a powerful and influential bloc in future elections.

The Gen-Z streamer from Medellín

The Weekly Digest

influencing Colombia's election :: WestCol's world

WestCol (Luis Fernando Villa), a 25-year-old streamer from Medellín with 15m followers, has emerged as an unexpected kingmaker in Colombia's presidential election, leveraging his platform to influence young voters. He conducts "sin filtro" livestreams with candidates, notably right-wing populist Abelardo de la Espriella, whose anti-establishment message resonates with youths who feel the system is rigged. This shift towards algorithms over traditional debates, coupled with the use of AI-generated videos by candidates, is transforming the political landscape. WestCol's success story inspires many, and his platform has become a key battleground, potentially tilting the election in favor of de la Espriella.

ASIA

The Weekly Digest

Visiting big brother :: The real winner in Myanmar's civil war is China

China is the true victor in Myanmar's civil war, having politically endorsed coup leader Min Aung Hlaing and strategically leveraging its economic and diplomatic influence over both the junta and ethnic rebel groups. As Myanmar's largest foreign investor, China secures critical access to the Indian Ocean, bypassing the Malacca Strait, and provides essential support to the regime while also coercing border rebel groups into ceasefires. China's pragmatic approach prioritizes stable borders, the flow of rare earths, and open infrastructure projects rather than a unified Myanmar, solidifying its role as the indispensable broker to all factions.

Dammed if they do :: Myanmar's junta revives a hated dam to court China

Myanmar's junta is reviving the controversial Myitsone dam project, suspended by public protest in 2011,

The Weekly Digest

primarily to curry favor with China and exert leverage over ethnic armies, rather than to meet energy needs. Despite persistent local opposition due to opaque deals, environmental threats, and the bulk of electricity going to China, the junta has imposed gag orders and coerced locals into committees supporting the project. This move aims to provoke confrontations with the Kachin Independence Army (KIA) to seize territory, reinforcing China's indispensable role as a trade and weapons supplier to both sides.

Yam today :: From Philippine staple to global sensation: the rise of ube

Ube, a purple yam from the Philippines, has transformed from a local staple into a global culinary sensation, featured in Western menus and drinks due to its photogenic hue and mild flavor. Historically a carbohydrate source, it is now predominantly used in desserts like halaya, its sweet and creamy taste gaining widespread recognition. However, Philippine ube

The Weekly Digest

growers are struggling to meet the soaring international demand, hampered by the yam's long maturation period, single annual yield, vulnerability to natural disasters, traditional farming methods, and growing competition from countries like Vietnam and China.

Hard sell :: Taiwan's opposition leader faced a tough crowd in America

Taiwan's opposition leader, Cheng Li-wun of the Kuomintang (KMT), encountered skepticism during her US tour as she defended her outreach to China, aimed at avoiding war. Despite critics accusing her of pandering to Xi Jinping and blocking defense spending, she reiterated her party's opposition to formal independence but pledged to fight back if China uses force. While she may propose legislation for domestic defense, these efforts are unlikely to reassure American officials, who have prioritized other KMT leaders advocating for a stronger defense budget. The Trump administration's higher-level access to rivals like Taichung city mayor Lu

The Weekly Digest

Shiow-yen underscores doubts about Ms. Cheng's approach to cross-strait relations.

Ashoka :: The problem with Narendra Modi's airport-building frenzy

Narendra Modi's government has impressively expanded India's operational airports from 74 to 164 in 12 years, with plans for 50 more, presenting them as symbols of modernity and development. However, this airport-building frenzy suffers from a critical flaw: poor last-mile connectivity. New facilities, like Noida International Airport near Delhi, are often geographically isolated and lack integrated public transport, forcing reliance on private vehicles. Similar issues plague Mumbai's second airport and others, demonstrating a broader neglect of crucial infrastructure links. While metro lines are also built to project modernity, they too often see low ridership due to a lack of feeder routes and pavements, making the overall investment less effective.

The Weekly Digest

CHINA

Going for green :: The Californication of middle-class Chinese diets

China's burgeoning middle class, now nearly 500m strong, is driving a "Californication" of diets, prioritizing healthier, safer, and simpler foods over traditional staples. This shift is fueled by increasing affluence and a deep-seated distrust stemming from past food-safety scandals. Demand for Western-familiar proteins and fruits like salmon, blueberries, and avocados is booming, with prices falling due to increased domestic production and imports. Organic farming areas and sales have significantly expanded, making healthier options more accessible. This trend is welcomed by the government, which seeks to address rising obesity and public health concerns, moving from merely "eating enough" to "eating well."

The Weekly Digest

How China still outworks the West :: Tails of toil

China's national labour medals, awarded by official trade unions, fail to accurately reflect the modern job market, disproportionately honoring engineers and party secretaries while underrepresenting gig economy workers and services. The geographical distribution of medals also favors richer cities like Beijing and Shanghai, despite their workers putting in fewer hours than those in poorer provinces. Although Chinese workers' average daily paid labor hours have shortened to match Western levels, the sheer proportion of 18- to 59-year-olds participating in the workforce (over 75%) means China still "outworks the West," often due to the absence of robust social safety nets.

News extortion is rife in China :: Cash for copy

News extortion is rampant in China, recently highlighted

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by authorities sentencing three men for extorting companies by threatening to publish fabricated negative stories online. This practice, however, extends beyond online scammers to state-media journalists, facilitated by China's strict media controls. The government's emphasis on "positive energy" reporting, coupled with the difficulty for media outlets to survive solely on news sales, incentivizes unethical behavior. The routine disappearance of unwelcome news reports due to censorship further enables this, making extortion "the most direct and effective method to make money through reporting."

Chaguan :: Comfort meets constraint in China's most 'liveable' city

Shaoxing, rated China's most "liveable" city, offers a pleasant blend of small-city ease and prosperity, attracting migrants with lower housing costs and job opportunities. This "high-income, low-pressure" existence is paradoxically accompanied by pervasive

The Weekly Digest

surveillance, which residents largely accept as a trade-off for safety. Despite its physical improvements and welcoming stance toward migrants, Shaoxing is not immune to national problems like declining birth rates and economic pressures, such as empty homes. The city represents a managed, manicured vision of the good life, dictated by aging cadres, where comfort coexists with significant societal and economic constraints.

INTERNATIONAL

Everything is negotiable :: Meet the world's new peacemakers

Autocratic regimes, including Pakistan, Turkey, China, and Qatar, are increasingly dominating global conflict mediation, involved in over 20 of 53 peace processes in 2025, while established democratic and UN-led efforts wane. These new peacemakers are driven by domestic

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prestige, regional stability, and commercial or geopolitical interests, leveraging unique access to groups often shunned by Western powers. Their deals prioritize stability, business, and trade over human rights and democracy, often employing coercive diplomacy, which can yield quicker ceasefires but typically results in less durable peace agreements, replacing comprehensive peacebuilding with stopgap measures.

The Telegram :: Asian allies are doomed to hug Donald Trump close

Asian allies, particularly Japan, dismiss "middle-power coalitions" to resist superpowers as an "embarrassing fantasy," understanding that only America can effectively deter China's growing regional dominance. Unlike European allies who often resent Trump's aggression, Japanese elites prioritize pragmatic security, viewing China as a significant threat. Japan, despite its economic and technological strengths, sees no viable alternative to America's nuclear umbrella, focusing

The Weekly Digest

instead on demonstrating its indispensability to US prosperity and technological primacy. This pragmatic approach, emphasizing technological collaboration over ideological alignment, urges other allies to adopt a more mature and realistic stance toward superpower relations.

BUSINESS

Pump v plug :: America's carmakers cannot escape Chinese EVs for ever

Detroit's "Big Three" carmakers—GM, Ford, and Stellantis—are relying on petrol-powered vehicles behind protectionist barriers, risking obsolescence as the global auto industry shifts to electric vehicles (EVs). Despite a short-term boost in share prices from continued petrol sales, past EV investments have led to significant write-downs and scaled-back plans. While US tariffs offer temporary protection, Chinese EV manufacturers

The Weekly Digest

are far ahead and are establishing a presence in Mexico and Canada, poised to eventually enter the American market. Detroit's history of retrenchment suggests a challenging future, as competition will inevitably arrive, forcing them to adapt or face further decline.

Fox pounces :: Fox, Roku and the next phase of the streaming wars

Fox Corporation is making a major move into the streaming landscape by acquiring Roku for \$22bn, aiming to become a formidable player in Hollywood. This strategic acquisition builds on Fox's prior purchase of Tubi and the launch of Fox One, and will combine its existing streaming assets with Roku's popular FAST service, the Roku Channel. This deal will give Fox a combined 11% share of streaming viewership in America, surpassing Disney, and highlights the increasing importance of advertising in the streaming wars. Roku will provide Fox with scale and valuable viewing data, enhancing its ad-targeting capabilities

The Weekly Digest

across all its services.

Oil, wind and fire :: The Iran war has boosted Equinor, Norway's energy giant

Norway's Equinor, Europe's largest hydrocarbon supplier, has seen its share price rise significantly due to increased European gas prices and Brent crude following the Iran war. However, this short-term gain masks underlying challenges as the company navigates between a maturing fossil-fuel business and scaled-back green ambitions. Equinor is prioritizing capital expenditure in its declining Norwegian oil and gas fields to sustain production, while foreign ventures are not expected to transform its fortunes. After facing rising costs and delays in renewables, the firm has curtailed green investments, now focusing on shareholder payouts, effectively settling into a role as a middle-aged cash cow.

Token reckoning :: Companies are

The Weekly Digest

scrambling to curtail soaring AI costs

Companies are grappling with surging AI costs, driven by the intensive processing power consumed by proliferating AI agents and token-heavy applications. This new budget management challenge has led many firms, including Meta and Amazon, to abandon internal AI leaderboards and re-evaluate their model choices, opting for less expensive, lagging-edge or open-source solutions for many tasks. Strategies include implementing spending caps for employees and leveraging new pricing plans from software vendors and cloud providers. Model-makers, while currently subsidizing services, face pressure to raise prices to achieve profitability, especially as Anthropic and OpenAI prepare for IPOs, signaling continued upward pressure on AI bills.

Tata's troubles :: Tata's big bets are yet to pay off

The Weekly Digest

India's Tata Group faces boardroom conflicts and challenges from large, speculative investments in new ventures like an airline, a digital super-app, smartphones, and semiconductors, which are absorbing vast capital without yielding commensurate returns. While its listed entities, particularly Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), demonstrate strong profitability, unlisted new businesses like Air India remain loss-making, hindering the group's overall return on capital employed. Compounding these issues are demands from a minority shareholder for an exit and a central bank mandate for Tata Sons, the holding company, to list publicly, a move resisted by Tata Trusts, which fears losing control and undermining its unique role in India's industrial development.

Bartleby :: How to launch a tech product

Tech companies typically follow a highly polished, predictable, and irony-free formula for product launches, characterized by slick presentations and a performative sense of "super-excitement." These events, often

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featuring speakers in casual attire, scripted hand-offs, and staged demonstrations, create a corporate safe space designed to convey technological breakthroughs. While serving to inform investors, developers, and users about product pipelines and set internal deadlines, the formulaic nature of these jamborees often lacks genuine spontaneity, with speakers personalizing features through bland examples and receiving only light, confused applause from audiences.

Schumpeter :: Tournament of losers

The World Cup in America has ironically become a "festival for corporate has-beens," with many major sponsors and broadcasters struggling in their respective industries. Top sportswear brands like Nike, Adidas, and Puma have seen their market values decline, facing increased competition and a lack of innovative products. Broadcasters, including Fox and ITV, are battling declining traditional TV viewership, while brewers contend with a rising temperance trend among young

The Weekly Digest

people. Despite record betting volumes, gambling firms also face existential threats from prediction markets. The tournament thus highlights the decline of old corporate giants, with streaming services and prediction markets poised to replace them.

FINANCE & ECONOMICS

AI-Econ 101 :: Meet the world's top AI-pilled economists

Academic economists have shown surprisingly limited interest in AI's transformative impact, with research remaining scarce and often abstract, unlike their rapid response to past crises. Many academics remain techno-skeptical, anticipating only modest productivity gains. The center of gravity for AI economics is shifting away from universities towards government bodies, which are building crucial data infrastructure, and

The Weekly Digest

increasingly to AI labs themselves. These labs offer better data access, influence with policymakers, and higher salaries, attracting top economists and reorienting research towards proprietary innovation. This shift, while yielding some valuable real-time intelligence, also raises concerns about conflicts of interest and the impartiality of research.

Buttonwood :: America's bull market has entered its manic phase

America's bull market has entered a "manic phase," with investor optimism giving way to euphoria, as evidenced by soaring stock prices and valuations, particularly exemplified by SpaceX's recent IPO. The rocketry firm, valued at \$1.8trn despite losses, saw its share price surge 40%, fueled by ambitious projections for its AI arm. This manic mood extends to the broader market, with the S&P 500 nearing dotcom bubble peaks. The options market, now functioning more as a casino, shows a dramatic increase in ultra-short contracts and call options

The Weekly Digest

nearly as expensive as puts, signaling aggressive speculation that prices will continue to rise, indicating a party that will eventually lead to a painful hangover.

Deal or no deal, oil prices will stay volatile for months :: The new abnormal

Despite the America-Iran memorandum of understanding to end the war and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, oil prices are projected to remain volatile for months, with pre-war \$60 crude unlikely to return soon. While Brent crude has fallen, full market recovery will be slow due to the extensive process of mine clearing, restarting production, and ramping up refining. Tanker passage will be delayed by demining efforts, and inbound vessels may not fully return for four to five months, keeping supply constrained. Iran's potential "fees" for passage and ongoing sanctions risks, coupled with rising summer demand and global stock replenishment efforts, point to continued high prices and market uncertainty well into next year.

The Weekly Digest

Life after zero :: A new golden age for Japanese banks comes with a catch

Japan's banking sector is entering a "golden age" with rising interest rates, leading to a doubling of Japanese bank shares since March 2024 and record profits for mega-banks. This shift ends three decades of strain caused by near-zero interest rates. However, smaller regional and shinkin community banks continue to struggle, facing challenges in attracting deposits and burdened by massive unrealized losses from low-return bonds bought during the zero-rate era. While some are pursuing mergers and creative accounting to manage stress, these vulnerabilities could imperil the banking system, particularly as Japan's aging population erodes their deposit base, making a reckoning inevitable as rates rise further.

Does Donald Trump make Latin America a good bet? :: The Donroe dividend

The Weekly Digest

Despite the unsettling disruptions of Donald Trump's second term—including trade conflicts and soaring energy prices—Latin America is experiencing a "Donroe dividend," becoming a surprisingly attractive investment destination. Foreign direct investment and mergers & acquisitions significantly increased in 2025, reversing previous declines, and Latin American stock markets have outperformed other emerging markets. This is partly due to the region's improved macroeconomic stability and Trump's desire for closer economic ties to dilute China's influence, leading to substantial American capital flowing into mining and other sectors. However, this prosperity is precarious, dependent on Trump's unpredictable attention span and the region's persistent infrastructure deficits and bureaucratic hurdles.

Free Exchange :: Europe buys the future, America builds it

A complex debate rages among economists over whether Europe is falling behind America, with differing

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interpretations of GDP figures. Paul Krugman argues that using "current PPP" shows Europe's spending power has kept pace, suggesting Europe benefits from cheaper American tech exports. Conversely, Philippe Aghion and Luis Garicano, favoring "constant PPP," contend that Europe's GDP per person, relative to America's, has significantly declined. The dispute highlights the mathematical complexities of comparing economic output across time and space, often leading to ethnographical observations about affluence. While Europe grows slower, the article suggests the AI era may be less forgiving, prompting questions about who is truly ahead.

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Biology's plague journal :: Ancient DNA is rewriting the history of plague

The Weekly Digest

Ancient DNA analysis, particularly from human teeth, is revolutionizing the understanding of plague, confirming its role in major historical epidemics and extending its known history far into prehistory. A new study in *Nature* provides the earliest evidence of plague, two lethal outbreaks 5,500 years ago among Siberian hunter-gatherers, challenging the long-held belief that dense, squalid cities were necessary for large-scale outbreaks. The findings suggest early plague was highly fatal, spread within close families, and potentially transmitted through bodily fluids or airborne droplets, even without flea-friendly mutations, providing crucial data for future vaccine development and disease monitoring.

Boy problems :: The coming El Niño could be the strongest ever recorded

A new El Niño has begun and is predicted to be the strongest ever recorded, with sea-surface temperatures potentially rising over 2.5°C, amplifying global warming

The Weekly Digest

effects and threatening a record-hot 2027. This recurring climatic pattern will redistribute heat and moisture across the planet, causing severe droughts in eastern and southern Africa, Central America, and parts of Asia, alongside heavy rains elsewhere. The UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation warns of impending humanitarian disasters in several African and Latin American countries, exacerbating existing conflicts and hunger. Implementing drought-tolerant seeds and storing fodder are crucial, but immediate action is needed.

Sweet teeth :: The chocolate industry is built on the labour of bloodsucking midges

The \$140bn global chocolate industry relies on the precise pollination of cacao plants, a process now confirmed by new research to be predominantly carried out by tiny, bloodsucking midges. A study by Eliza Van de Sande identified biting midges as the key pollinators, frequently interacting with the reproductive parts of cacao flowers and carrying pollen. This discovery is vital

The Weekly Digest

for improving cacao yields amidst tight markets and rising prices, especially as climate change makes plantations warmer and drier, conditions unfavorable for midge activity. Agroforestry techniques, providing shade and humidity, are suggested as a way to encourage more pollinators and enhance production.

Leavesdropping :: How plants keep tabs on the competition

Plants engage in chemical "espionage" to monitor their competitors, as demonstrated by research revealing they communicate via volatile organic compounds (VOCs). An experiment with barley varieties showed that slow-growing plants exposed to VOCs from fast-growing neighbors significantly accelerated their growth, anticipating shading risks. Conversely, fast-growing plants reduced their growth when near slower rivals, reallocating resources towards metabolically expensive defensive measures. This "eavesdropping" ability allows plants to adjust their

The Weekly Digest

growth strategies accordingly. Farmers could potentially leverage these VOCs to boost crop productivity, either by encouraging faster growth for higher yields or inducing protective compounds against pests.

Well Informed :: A new drug targets one of cancer's master switches

Daraxonrasib, a new drug from Revolution Medicines, has achieved remarkable results in pancreatic cancer clinical trials, nearly doubling median survival times from 6.7 to 13.2 months, garnering widespread scientific acclaim. The drug targets and inhibits the KRAS protein, a molecular switch that drives most pancreatic cancers and is implicated in 20% of all cancers, a target previously deemed "undruggable" for four decades. This breakthrough not only offers significant hope as a first-line treatment for pancreatic cancer but also opens new avenues for treating other RAS-driven cancers, including colorectal, lung, and even childhood neuroblastoma, potentially transforming cancer treatment

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for millions.

CULTURE

Look on my works :: Barack Obama has built a monument to himself

Barack Obama's new \$850m Presidential Centre in Chicago, a Brutalist ziggurat, is the most expensive presidential library in history, serving as both a public archive and a personal monument. These unique American institutions allow former leaders to shape their legacies without critical oversight, blending public function with private funding. Obama's center, a "fully digital" library managed by his foundation, grants him greater control over exhibitions. This perpetuates a long-standing tension between mythmaking and historical fact, seen in other presidential libraries' selective portrayals and omissions, reinforcing a

The Weekly Digest

somewhat regal aura around the executive branch, despite the significant public cost.

See you in court :: What the largest-ever shareholder judgment reveals about Russia

Martin Sixsmith's "Suing the Kremlin" vividly details Vladimir Putin's authoritarian consolidation of power through the two-decade legal battle over the expropriation of Yukos oil company and the imprisonment of its boss, Mikhail Khodorkovsky. The book chronicles how former Yukos shareholders, led by lawyer Tim Osborne, secured a landmark \$50bn arbitration award against Russia for breaching an energy-investment treaty. Despite Russia's non-payment, the victory represented a significant humbling for Putin, exposing the Kremlin's willingness to intimidate opponents and demonstrating that justice against such a regime is best sought through cool strategy and foreign legal systems.

The Weekly Digest

My con and only :: Why Westerners are falling for love scams

Carlos Barragán's "The Yahoo Boys" explores the booming phenomenon of romance fraud, where "love scammers" in west Africa exploit loneliness in the West, as exemplified by his mother's personal experience. While some crime syndicates are sophisticated, many Nigerian "Yahoo Boys" are unemployed youths using simple scripts, surviving on small gift cards. These scammers succeed by providing attention to lonely individuals, using tactics like fake illnesses or blackmail. The book anticipates AI complicating these scams by enabling mass personalization, but also suggests AI could offer safer virtual relationships, potentially challenging the traditional scammer model.

Give me s?more :: Adults are going back to summer camp

Adult sleepaway camps, such as Camp Social in the

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Pocono Mountains, are rapidly growing in popularity across America and Europe, offering grown-ups a much-needed respite from modern stresses. These retreats provide a structured, pre-planned schedule in natural settings, allowing participants to reconnect with themselves and indulge in nostalgic "kidulting" activities like making friendship bracelets or kayaking. Crucially, these camps address a "friendship recession" by fostering real-world social connections, with many attendees arriving solo and leaving as friends across diverse age groups, offering a unique blend of adventure and community for a fee of around \$1,000 for a long weekend.

The road less travelled :: Harry Styles and other megastars now expect you to come to them

Megastars like Harry Styles, Beyoncé, and Coldplay are increasingly adopting a touring strategy of performing longer, multi-night runs in fewer cities worldwide. Harry

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Styles's new tour, for instance, features 68 concerts in just seven cities, including extended residencies in London and New York. This shift reduces the grueling travel schedule for artists and maximizes profits by minimizing costs associated with transporting elaborate sets and managing complex logistics. While generating massive economic windfalls for the chosen host cities, this trend means smaller regional cities are bypassed, leaving fans to travel further to experience live shows, transforming concerts into a form of cultural pilgrimage.

Man of mystery :: Harlan Coben, Netflix's new darling, has a mystery you can solve

Harlan Coben, an American thriller writer, has become Netflix's new favorite, with his "Harlan Coben's" series dominating the platform despite sometimes being criticized as cheesy and confusing. His viral success, with over 100m books sold and numerous popular adaptations, stems from his talent for crafting gripping plots that compel viewers to keep watching. These

The Weekly Digest

British-set thrillers, often featuring family tragedies, lavish backdrops, and melodramatic plot twists, are widely consumed as "comforting" entertainment. Coben believes their appeal lies in universal themes of love, family, and redemption, regardless of the "red-blooded murder" and shocking events.

ECONOMIC & FINANCIAL INDICATORS

Indicators :: Economic data, commodities and markets

No significant coverage this issue.

OBITUARY

The swimming-pool genius :: David Hockney believed in working from the heart

The Weekly Digest

David Hockney, Britain's bold and innovative painter, died aged 88, celebrated for his vibrant double portraits and iconic swimming pool series that captured the allure of Californian life. His most famous work, "Portrait of an Artist (Pool With Two Figures)," exemplified his ability to blend deep personal emotion with meticulous artistic technique, reflecting a painful breakup and his mother's solace. Hockney was a lifelong explorer of art, from defying academic trends to embracing new materials and digital painting on iPads. His extensive oeuvre, including monumental digital murals, consistently depicted his life, sexuality, and landscapes, ultimately forming a "Bayeux Tapestry" of his remarkable artistic journey.